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DUBAI ANNOUNCES 10-DAY MOURNING FOR AHMED

Sheikh Ahmed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, the younger brother of His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, died yesterday at the age of 76, the Ruler's Court announced. The Court declared 10 days of official mourning across Dubai, beginning yesterday, with flags to be flown at half-mast throughout the period. President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan extended his sincere condolences to Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid on the passing of Sheikh Ahmed. Condolences also poured in from Arab leaders. King Hamad Bin Eisa Al Khalifa of Bahrain, Sheikh Mishal Al Ahmad Al Jaber Al Sabah, Emir of Kuwait, and Sultan Haitham Bin Tariq of Oman sent cables of condolences to Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid.

SEE ALSO P10

UAE AIMS TO ADVANCE PEACE, SECURITY AT UN SESSION

Nation continues to be a trusted partner

NEW YORK

Sheikh Abdullah Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs, is leading the UAE delegation at the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA81) in New York from today to September 28.

Throughout High-Level Week, the UAE delegation will engage with Member States, UN officials, and international partners to advance solutions to global challenges, reinforce international peace and security, and strengthen a multilateral system that is better equipped to respond effectively. In light of the heightened geopolitical tensions, the UAE continues to consolidate its position as a trusted partner in supporting security and stability. The UAE's commitment to dialogue and de-escalation has never wavered, and its strategic autonomy has been maintained.

Clear and consistent record

The UAE brings to New York a clear and consistent record reflecting its unwavering approach aimed at advancing peace through sustained diplomacy, humanitarian leadership, and a conviction that dialogue is the only path to lasting stability. The UAE's priorities for UNGA81 are guided by three strategic objectives: advancing conflict resolution, consolidating global stabil-

GARGASH: WE NEED A NEW MINDSET

Arab countries and Iran need to engage in a direct dialogue over the future of the region rather than leaving strategic discussions largely to Tehran and Washington, Dr Anwar Mohammed Gargash, Diplomatic Adviser to the UAE President, said, calling for a "new mindset" in relations with Iran.

Speaking during an AI Monitor panel discussion in New York ahead of the UN General Assembly's High-Level Week, Gargash said Iran viewed itself as a regional hegemon and preferred to discuss major strategic issues with the US. "We need a new mindset," Gargash said. He argued that discussions about the kind of region its countries want, the stability they seek and development, which he said was closely linked to stability, should take place not only at an Iranian-American level but also at an Iranian-Arab level.

Gargash said the UAE and other countries may also have to contend with an unstable Iran for some time, stressing that this did not necessarily mean a change of government in Tehran but was an important factor in determining how regional states dealt with their neighbour. He also warned that the current conflict could become prolonged, pointing to complications including Yemen and economic sanctions, but said greater diplomatic engagement was needed to find a way forward. "This is the period for greater diplomacy," Gargash said.

—Khitam Al Amir, Chief News Editor

ity, and fostering the values of tolerance and peaceful coexistence; supporting UN reforms for greater efficiency and effectiveness, including through the responsible use of artificial intelligence; and championing climate action and sustainable water solutions.

On this occasion, Sheikh Abdullah affirmed the UAE's support for the UN80 Initiative and for the shared efforts to build a more effective, efficient, and responsive United Nations capable of delivering on its core mandates. Sheikh Abdullah said, "At

a time when our region and the wider world face unprecedented challenges to peace, security, and stability, the UAE believes that dialogue, respect for international law, and effective multilateral cooperation are more important than ever. UNGA81 provides an opportunity to restore confidence in the role of international law within the UN system, uphold the principles of the Charter of the UN, and advance practical solutions that promote peace, security, and sustainable development."

— WAM

SEE ALSO P12, 15, P-II, IV

US visa applicants face new social media check

New rules cover media workers, USMCA professionals and dependants

DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

US visa applicants in several categories will face expanded scrutiny of their online presence from October 1, with the US Department of State instructing newly-covered applicants to keep their social media profiles public or open as part of the visa screening process.

The expanded review will cover applicants for I visas for foreign media representatives, and TN and TD visas for USMCA professionals and their dependants. The State Department said applicants in these categories must set the privacy settings on all their social media profiles to "public" or "open" to facilitate the vetting process.

The move is relevant to Gulf-based professionals, media workers and families travelling to the US, and comes as Washington expands the use of online screening while also introducing broader changes to visa and immigration processing.

'Every available info'

The latest announcement, dated September 18, expands online presence reviews that already apply to a range of visa categories, including students, temporary workers, exchange visitors and religious workers.

The department said it relies on "every available source of information" during visa

EXPANDED ONLINE PRESENCE REVIEW

- I visas – foreign media representatives
- TN visas – eligible Canadian and Mexican professionals working temporarily in the US under the USMCA
- TD visas – spouses and children of TN professionals

Applicants in these categories have been instructed to make their social media profiles public or open.

screening to identify applicants who may be inadmissible to the US, including those who pose a threat to national security or public safety. "Every visa adjudication is fundamentally a national security decision," the department said. It added that applicants must be able to demonstrate their eligibility for the visa requested, including a genuine intention to comply with the terms of admission. "Receiving a US visa remains a privilege granted at the government's discretion, not an entitlement," the department said.

The new requirement adds to online presence screening already used for several other visa categories, including F-1 and M-1 students; H-1B, H-3 and certain H-4 temporary workers and dependants; J-1 and J-2 exchange visitors; K-1, K-2 and K-3 fiancé and dependant visas; Q cultural exchange participants; R religious workers; and S, T and U visa applicants, as well as certain diplomatic and official visa categories.

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